

PICK IT UP — SEATTLE —

Captain Can and the **Messy Block**

ONE PERSON. ONE PIECE. ONE BETTER CITY.

A CLEAN
SEATTLE
♥
STARTS
WITH YOU.



BE A LITTER HERO TODAY! ♥

On a bright
Saturday morning,
Mia stepped outside
with a bounce in her step
and a snack in her hand.

The city sparkled.

Well... almost.



Right beside the sidewalk
was a **crumpled cup**.

A candy wrapper
danced across the street.

And a napkin was stuck
in a bush like a tiny
white flag.

Mia frowned.
'Who put all
THAT there?'



Suddenly—

CLANK!
CLUNK!
KER-PLINK!

A trash can at the corner
wiggled.

Then it spoke.

‘Not me!’

Mia nearly
dropped her snack.



The trash can stretched out
two little metal arms.

‘I’m Captain Can!’

he announced.

Defender of sidewalks!

Protector of parks!

Keeper of... banana peels!

Mia giggled.

‘Banana peels?’

‘Especially
banana peels.’



Captain Can
pointed down
the block.

There were cups.

Wrappers.

Straws.

Receipts.

And one very
lonely sock.

Mia blinked.

‘Is that trash
too?’

Captain Can
squinted.

‘That one is...
complicated.’



Then something behind them
began to rumble.

≡ **GRRRRRUMBLE....!** ≡

The litter on the ground
started swirling together.

Cup by cup.
Wrapper by wrapper.

Until—

≡ **POOF!** ≡

A giant, goofy creature appeared.



‘I am the
MESS MONSTER!’
he boomed.

He had a **cup** for a hat,
a **pizza box** for a belly,
and two **straws**
sticking out of his ears.

Captain Can groaned.
‘Oh brother.
Him again.’



The Mess Monster
waddled down
the sidewalk.

Every time someone
dropped litter—

PLOP!
—he grew **BIGGER!**

A straw on
the ground?

BIGGER!

A wrapper tossed
aside?

BIGGER!

A cup left in
the grass?

BIGGER!



‘But why would anyone
drop trash on the ground?’
Mia asked.

The Mess Monster shrugged.

‘Too busy!’

‘Too far!’

‘Someone else
will get it!’

Captain Can
shook his lid.

‘Nope, nope,
and **NOPE.**’



Captain Can leaned
toward Mia.

‘Want to know a secret?’

Mia nodded.

‘The Mess Monster has
one big weakness.’

‘What?’

Captain Can whispered.

‘People who care.’



See it?
Pick it up!
Spot a can?
Toss it in!
KER-PLUNK!



The Mess Monster
suddenly shrank.

“HEY!” Mia’s
eyes widened.

“It worked!”

Captain Can grinned.

**“One person,
One piece.”**



A boy walking his dog
noticed a wrapper.

He picked it up.

≡ **KER-PLUNK!** ≡

A woman waiting
by a bench
grabbed a cup.

≡ **KER-PLUNK!** ≡

Two kids carried
an empty bottle
to the nearest can.

≡ **KER-PLUNK!** ≡

The Mess Monster
grew smaller
and smaller.



‘No! Stop being responsible!’

cried the Mess Monster.
He was now barely
taller than Mia’s shoe.

‘Walk past it!’

‘Pretend you
didn’t see it!’

‘Leave it for
somebody else!’

Mia put her
hands on her hips.

‘Nice try.’



Then Mia spotted
a tiny gum wrapper.

She picked it up.

The Mess Monster
gasped.

“Not the
tiny ones too!”

Mia smiled.

“Tiny things
count.”

KER-PLUNK!



With one last —
PFFFFFFT!

— the Mess Monster shrank
into a little ball of
crumpled paper.

Captain Can
scooped him up.
“In you go.”

PLOP!

From inside
the can came
a tiny voice:

‘Rude.’



Mia looked around.
The sidewalk looked **brighter**.
The park looked **happier**.
The flowers **weren't** hiding
behind cups
and wrappers
anymore.
Even the birds
seemed **pleased**.
One bird **chirped**.
Captain Can
nodded seriously.
“He said
thank you.”



‘But Captain Can,’
Mia asked,
‘what if I don’t
see a trash can?’

‘Good question!’
Captain Can said,
‘Hold onto your trash
until you find one.’

‘And if you see
one little piece you
can safely pick up?’
Mia knew the answer.

‘Leave the place
a little better than
I found it.’



Captain Can smiled.
“You don’t need a cape.
You don’t need superpowers.
You don’t even need
a talking trash can.”

Mia raised an eyebrow.
“That last one helps.”
“Fair point,”
said Captain Can.



The block was **clean**.

The air felt **fresh**.

Mia felt **proud**.

Captain Can **smiled**.

Every small choice
made a **big** difference.

One person.

One piece.

One better Seattle.

And they all lived
happily ever after. ❤️



THANK YOU!

You're part of the Pick It Up Seattle movement.
Together we can keep our city clean,
kind, and beautiful!



Small actions can make
a big difference.

Thank you for being
part of the solution!

Learn more, share your cleanups,
and get involved at:

PickItUpSeattle.org



JOIN THE MOVEMENT!

